

The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter



Photograph: Getty Images

Israel and **Iran** agreed to halt strikes, but threatened to retaliate if attacks resumed. **Donald Trump** said peace negotiations were “proceeding” and that a naval blockade remained in place. Israel reportedly stopped its attacks following [a request from the American president](#) after fighting reignited on Sunday. The price of Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, fell to around \$94.

American stocks climbed as the value of chipmaking firms rebounded from a sell-off; markets were also reassured by Iran’s and Israel’s announcements. The S&P 500 and the NASDAQ closed 0.3% and 0.9% higher, respectively. Both indices slumped last week after strong American jobs data raised the prospect of an interest-rate hike and investors dumped stocks over fears of an [AI bubble](#).

A federal judge ruled that Mr Trump’s [proposed charge of \\$100,000](#) on new applications for **H-1B visas** was unlawful and must be dropped. Several states sued the Trump administration after the higher fee was announced in September. The visa is mostly used by technology firms hiring foreign graduates; it had previously cost about \$2,500 in legal and filing fees to secure.

Germany and **France** abandoned plans to jointly build a **next-generation fighter jet**. The Future Combat Air System, which also involves Spain, had been [plagued by bickering](#) between French and German defence firms, including over how to split up the work. Germany's government told French media that Friedrich Merz, the chancellor, and Emmanuel Macron, France's president, concluded that the companies were unable to "come together".

Apple announced improvements to its artificial-intelligence tools at its Worldwide Developers Conference, including a long-delayed overhaul of **Siri**. The digital assistant will soon use AI to offer personalised chatbot services to its users; its familiar voice is also becoming customisable. Investors' reactions to the updates were muted. John Ternus [takes over from Tim Cook](#) as Apple's boss on September 1st.

Sir Keir Starmer, Britain's prime minister, gave **technology companies** operating in the country three months to introduce controls stopping minors from sending or receiving nude images on their devices. Failure to do so voluntarily will result in legislation requiring it, he said. Sir Keir's announcement came amid reports that he is planning to introduce a [social-media ban](#) for children under 16.

New York City ramped up security ahead of Mr Trump's appearance at the **National Basketball Association** finals at Madison Square Garden. Zohran Mamdani, the mayor, is also going. Ticket prices for game 3 of the [NBA](#) finals, the first to be hosted by the New York **Knicks** since 1999, are eye-wateringly expensive. Two VIP seats, normally reserved for celebrities, were auctioned for \$1m.

Figure of the day: 1.45bn, the population of India, accounting for a sixth of humanity. But, despite widespread poverty, high rates of marriage and relatively young mothers, the [fertility rate is falling fast](#).



Photograph: EPA

China's dictator visits North Korea's

Xi Jinping [arrived in North Korea](#) on Monday for a state visit. The Chinese president's first overseas trip this year will showcase China as a global power capable of friendly relations even with troublemakers.

Underlying the diplomacy is discomfort in China over North Korea's [ties with Russia](#). The two countries agreed to a defence pact in 2024; the regime in Pyongyang has sent troops and weapons to support Russia's war on Ukraine. China wants to draw North Korea closer, timing the visit just before the 65th anniversary of their friendship treaty next month.

Mr Xi is unlikely to spoil the mood by criticising North Korea's nuclear-weapons programme, which it once sought to curtail. Last week Kim Jong Un, North Korea's dictator, toured a uranium-enrichment facility and inspected a new warship. North Korea says its nuclear status is irreversible and Mr Xi is not inclined to argue. America, bogged down in the Middle East, may not be able to do much about it on its own.

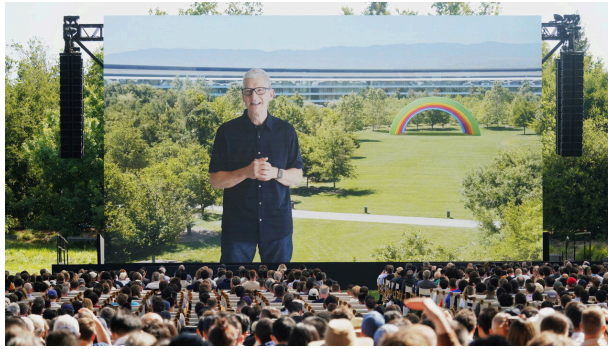


Photograph: Reuters

Tata's boardroom drama

Infighting at one of India's most prominent companies threatens to spill over when the board of Tata Trusts, a charity that owns 66% of the sprawling Tata conglomerate, meets on Monday. The board is split on whether to comply with a demand from India's central bank for Tata Sons, the holding company that owns the individual businesses, to list its shares publicly. A listing is a requirement for "shadow banks" over a certain size. Tata Sons falls into that category because of debt held at its subsidiary companies. The board of Tata Sons will meet on Friday.

A more personal feud over succession is also brewing at the top of the Tata empire, which spans everything from airlines to iPhone-assembly plants and jewellery stores. Noel Tata, chair of Tata Trusts, is reportedly pushing to secure an important role for his son, Neville—an attempt that pits him against N. Chandrasekaran, the chair of Tata Sons and the first person with no ties to the family to run the conglomerate.



Photograph: Eyevine

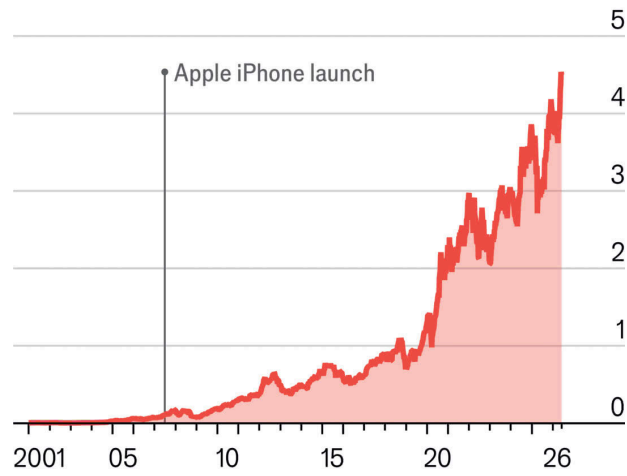
Can Apple's Siri compete with ChatGPT?

Apple's Worldwide Developers Conference, an annual software jamboree, began on Monday. The company announced a makeover of Siri, its digital assistant, redesigning its interface to function more like an artificial-intelligence chatbot. Apple has spent far less than other big tech firms on [AI-model development](#). Rather than competing in the model wars, Apple's bosses are betting that ensuring its devices are the main way users get access to AI is the smarter (and cheaper) path.

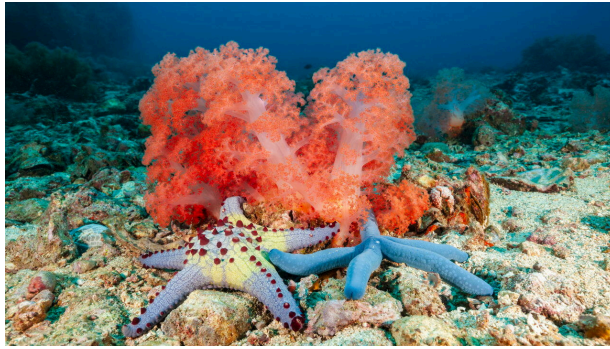
Apple itself is entering a new era. Tim Cook, the boss, is preparing to hand over to John Ternus on September 1st. Mr Cook's 15-year tenure was an enormous [financial success](#); Apple's market capitalisation grew from \$350bn to \$4.6trn. But that rise was largely built on products released before he took over. Can Apple produce another smash hit on the scale of the iPhone? The conference may provide a clue.

Core blimey

Apple, market capitalisation, \$trn



Source: LSEG Workspace



Photograph: Science Photo Library

The world's ailing oceans

The decline in the health of the oceans is accelerating. The Starfish Barometer, an annual measure of ocean health—published on Monday by Mercator Ocean International, an ocean-monitoring firm—warns that the response is inadequate. Sea levels rose by an average of 4.2mm a year between 2012 and 2025, nearly double the rate of the previous decade, according to the barometer, which measures indicators such as marine life, coral bleaching and plastic pollution. Ocean [warming](#) is also escalating. Severe marine heatwaves affected a fifth of the global ocean in June last year.

But there are also hopeful developments. The High Seas Treaty, which took effect in January, aims to protect marine life in nearly two-thirds of the ocean that lies outside national borders. Rules limiting harmful subsidies for fisheries and protections for sharks and rays came into force last year. Plenty of organisations are trying to help; more than 40 funds and over 2,000 startups focus on ocean technology. Still, say the monitors, just 3.2% of the ocean is truly protected.



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 GMT on Friday to [\[email protected\]](#). We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Monday: What is the capital of the Mexican state of Nuevo León?

I doubt if there is anything in the world uglier than a Midwestern city.

Frank Lloyd Wright